

WENXUAN SUN

Department of Finance
University of Tennessee, Knoxville
Haslam Business Building, Room 307
Knoxville, TN 37996-0540

Updated: September 2026
(518) 596-6059
wsun22@vols.utk.edu
[Personal Website](#)

EDUCATION	University of Tennessee, Knoxville Ph.D. Candidate in Finance Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute M.S. in Quantitative Finance and Risk Analytics Xi'an International Studies University B.S. in Accounting	Expected 2027 2019 2018
RESEARCH INTERESTS	Corporate Finance, Labor and Finance, Corporate Taxation, Innovation	
WORKING PAPERS	Silencing Salary Talk: How Salary History Bans Affect Corporate Investment and Performance , with Matthew Serfling. – <i>Job Market Paper</i> – 2026: Eastern Finance Association (EFA) Annual Meeting – 2025: Financial Management Association (FMA) Annual Meeting – 2025: Southern Finance Association (SFA) Annual Meeting Tax Incentives and Unexpected Investment Responses: Evidence from ERTA The Role of IP Protection Statutes in Shaping M&A Target Choices , with Zhengzhuo Li. – 2026: Southwestern Finance Association (SWFA) Annual Meeting – 2025: Financial Management Association (FMA) Annual Meeting – 2025: Southern Finance Association (SFA) Annual Meeting	
WORK IN PROGRESS	Acquisition Announcement Returns and Deal Quality , with Tingting Liu and Danni Tu.	
TEACHING EXPERIENCE	University of Tennessee, Knoxville <i>Instructor</i> – Financial Modeling (FINC 402) – Survey of Financial Management (FINC 301) <i>Teaching Assistant</i> – Financial Management (FINC 306) – Quantitative Tools for Finance (FINC 311) – Financial Management Theory & Practice (FINC 457, FINC 555)	<i>Average Evaluation: 4.3/5.0</i> Spring 2026 Summer 2025 Fall 2022, Fall 2023 Fall 2023, Spring 2024 Fall 2024 - Present
HONORS AND AWARDS	Haslam Fellowship, University of Tennessee GSS Travel Award, University of Tennessee	2022–Present 2025

ACADEMIC SERVICE *Ad Hoc Referee*

- International Review of Finance

Conference Discussant

- Eastern Finance Association Annual Meeting 2026
- Financial Management Association Annual Meeting 2025
- Southern Finance Association Annual Meeting 2025

SKILLS

Stata, SAS, R, Python

DISSERTATION
COMMITTEE

Tingting Liu (Co-Chair)
Professor of Finance
University of Tennessee, Knoxville
Email: tliu22@utk.edu
Phone: (865) 974-3216

Matthew Serfling (Co-Chair)
Professor of Finance
University of Tennessee, Knoxville
Email: mserflin@utk.edu
Phone: (865) 974-1716

Daniel Weagley
Associate Professor of Finance
University of Tennessee, Knoxville
Email: dweagley@utk.edu
Phone: (865) 974-5061

James Chyz
Professor of Accounting
University of Tennessee, Knoxville
Email: jchyz@utk.edu
Phone: (865) 974-1701

PAPER ABSTRACTS

Silencing Salary Talk: How Salary History Bans Affect Corporate Investment and Performance, with Matthew Serfling.

We study how firms' access to labor-market information affects investment and performance. To do so, we exploit salary history bans (SHBs), which restrict employers from asking applicants about prior pay, as shocks that remove a low-cost but potentially imperfect signal of worker productivity and expected labor costs. Using staggered SHB adoption in a difference-in-differences design, we find that firms reduce capital expenditures and R&D while improving investment efficiency. Productivity, profitability, and firm value rise in the short-to-medium run, though these gains attenuate over time, consistent with persistently lower investment eventually constraining growth capacity. Additional findings suggest that SHBs create an input-information tradeoff: removing salary history raises uncertainty about future labor costs and match quality, discouraging irreversible investment, but also reduces reliance on an informative but imperfect signal, leading firms to make more disciplined hiring and capital-allocation decisions.

Tax Incentives and Unexpected Investment Responses: Evidence from ERTA

This paper studies how firms allocate investment when tax policy simultaneously changes incentives for physical capital and R&D. The Economic Recovery Tax Act of 1981 (ERTA) provides a useful setting because it accelerated depreciation deductions for physical capital while introducing the first federal incremental R&D tax credit. Whereas prior research typically studies these investment margins separately, I examine how firms adjust them jointly. To address the challenge that ERTA was a nationwide reform implemented amid large macroeconomic changes, I construct predetermined cross-sectional exposure to its capital provisions. Using historical tax law and the 1977 BEA Capital Flow Table, I measure industry-level changes in depreciation benefits and map them to firms using historical industry assignments and pre-reform capital intensity. This design provides firm-level evidence on whether tax incentives expand physical capital and R&D together or induce reallocation across the two margins.

The Role of IP Protection Statutes in Shaping M&A Target Choices, with Zhengzhuo Li.

We examine how employee intellectual property (IP) protections affect acquisition activity and innovation. Exploiting the staggered adoption of state statutes that limit employers' claims over independently developed employee inventions, we find that adopting firms become less likely to be acquired and state-level acquisition activity declines. The effect is stronger among innovation-intensive firms, consistent with reduced acquirer control over future employee-generated ideas. Firms reduce R&D after adoption, while patent counts, citations, patent values, and inventor inflows increase. Acquirers also experience lower long-run abnormal returns. Overall, stronger employee IP rights reshape innovation incentives, firm boundaries, and the market for corporate control.